Article 1

Why TomoClub Exists - And the Side of Education Innovation We Don’t See

Over the last 5 and a half years, our team has spent a lot of time talking to school leaders across different countries. Some conversations were formal, many weren’t. They happened at conferences, podcasts, after panels, or in follow-ups where people talked more openly.

And if you actually talk with school leaders, one thing becomes clear pretty quickly. It’s not that people aren’t trying. Teachers care, school leaders care. Teams are doing their best to make things work, often while juggling constraints most people never see.

And yet, the same pattern keeps showing up.

In many systems, the scale of what schools are handling never makes it into public view. In the US, nearly **16% of teachers either changed schools or left the profession in a single year**. Behind those numbers are leaders rebuilding teams mid-year, reshuffling schedules, and making hundreds of student-impacting decisions quietly, without headlines.

Thoughtful innovation is happening inside schools all the time, but very little of it is visible. When stories do get told, they usually focus on people, titles, or outcomes. What rarely surfaces are the decisions underneath - the trade-offs, the context, the thinking that actually moves things forward.

Once you start noticing that, you see it everywhere.

Why We’re Creating The Innovation Hall

The Innovation Hall exists because of that gap.

Not because there aren’t enough people doing good work in education, but because the work itself often goes unnoticed. We hear about outcomes and initiatives, but rarely about the mindset that shaped them or the trade-offs that made them possible.

Innovation in education is often imagined as something bold or disruptive. In practice, it’s usually quieter than that. It happens inside systems that are accountable, political, and understandably risk-aware. From the outside, progress can look slow or incremental, even when meaningful shifts are happening beneath the surface.

The Innovation Hall is our attempt to make that quieter work visible.

It isn’t an awards list or a ranking. And it isn’t about celebrating personalities. It’s about decisions and context. About what was tried, what didn’t work the first time, and what eventually moved things forward anyway.

Why This First Story Starts With TomoClub

If we're asking others to be open about their thinking, it feels important to start there ourselves.

So the first story in The Innovation Hall focuses on ***TomoClub***. Not as a founder spotlight or a polished origin story, but as a way to make our own assumptions visible before turning the lens outward.

TomoClub didn't begin with a product idea. It began with a frustration that kept surfacing across different conversations and contexts. Schools were working hard, but not always preparing students for the world they were stepping into.

That frustration shaped how TomoClub thinks about learning, skills, and systems. And it's also why The Innovation Hall exists in the first place.

A Company That Started With Frustration, Not a Solution

We believe schools are doing a decent job preparing students for assessments. But it is far less consistent when it comes to preparing them for *decision-making, collaboration, uncertainty, or change. (we see them as super important life skills!)*

This wasn't about people not caring. Most educators were doing their best within systems designed to be careful and slow to change. Safety mattered. Accountability mattered. But adaptability often came last.

At some point, this stopped being just an observation for us. We started thinking about the kind of education we would want for our own kids and realized we weren't fully comfortable with what the system currently prioritized.

A conversation with a close friend pushed the thinking further: *if this feels broken, why keep talking about it instead of trying something?*

That question became the starting point for TomoClub - not with a solution, but with a decision to step in and engage more honestly.

Two Founders, Two Schooling Journeys, One Conclusion

When we talk about why TomoClub exists, this is usually where the conversation lands.

Our co-founder, **Manik,** almost always starts by laughing about how he went to 7 schools in his childhood.

"I studied across seven different schools, boards, and systems," he says. "Everything kept changing - the syllabus, the rules, the expectations." What didn't change much was the role of the teacher. "If the teacher was good, the system worked. If they weren't, it didn't really matter which board it was."

That experience shaped how Manik looks at education today.
"At some point, I stopped seeing education as a syllabus problem," he says. "It's a system problem. People, incentives, and design choices matter more than we like to admit."



Our co-founders Manik & Avinash

Our other co-founder, **Avinash Bansal's** story usually follows right after, partly because it's the complete opposite.

"I went to one school my entire life," he says. "One Catholic school. Very structured. Very disciplined. Academically, it did exactly what it was supposed to do." Exams weren't the issue. "I was prepared for tests. That part was fine."

But when the conversation shifts, his tone does too.
"Most of my confidence, communication, and self-awareness came much later," Avinash says. "College societies. Competitions. Early entrepreneurship. Being thrown into situations where you have to figure things out."

What kept standing out to us was how often these two very different stories landed in the same place. Manik saw how much a system could vary depending on who was teaching. Avinash saw how much a system could miss even when it was working well.

Different paths. Same realization. School prepares you to be assessed. Life asks you to decide, collaborate, adapt, and keep learning when there's no answer key.

Why TomoClub Focused on Skills, Not Syllabi

From the beginning, we weren't interested in adding more content to classrooms. It already felt like students were carrying enough of that.

The belief was pretty simple. Knowledge changes quickly. What you memorize today can be outdated tomorrow. But the ability to learn, to work with others, and to adapt when things don't go as planned sticks around much longer.

So instead of asking what students should learn next, we kept coming back to a different question: *how does learning actually happen?*

That shift led us to focus on skills like:

- learning how to learn
- problem-solving and critical thinking
- collaboration and communication
- decision-making under uncertainty

These weren't treated as add-ons or enrichment. We saw them as infrastructure - the kind that quietly supports everything else students are asked to do, in school and beyond.

What Working With Schools Taught Us About Innovation

As we began working more closely with schools, another reality became clear.

Most schools weren't ignoring skills like collaboration, decision-making, or self-awareness. They were just struggling to fit them in. In many places, these skills were squeezed into a 15-minute advisory period, expected to be "embedded" across other subjects, or delivered through recorded videos students barely engaged with. On paper, the box was checked. In practice, the learning rarely stuck.



TomoClub Team with school leaders in the US

This wasn't because schools didn't care. Every decision carries weight, and risk isn't theoretical. Trying something new competes with timetables, exams, parent expectations, and the very real fear of breaking what already works.

Innovation also competes with urgency. There is always something more immediate to deal with. Trust matters more than ideas, and agreement doesn't always translate into action.

That's when an important distinction became clear to us. Believing in innovation is one thing. Implementing it, inside real systems with real constraints, is something else entirely.

Why AI Literacy Became the Entry Point

The rise of AI changed the conversation.

Unlike many past trends, AI introduced immediate uncertainty. Policy pressure. Parental concern. Fear of falling behind.

Teacher professional development emerged as the most practical entry point:

- No parent consent required
- Built-in PD days
- Clear urgency
- Immediate relevance

AI literacy wasn't treated as a standalone topic. It became a lens to explore critical thinking, ethical decision-making, tool awareness, and adaptability.

This wasn't a shift away from our philosophy. It was a system-aligned way to enter schools.

What We're Still Figuring Out

To be honest, we don't have this all figured out. And the more time we spend working with schools, the more aware we are of how complicated change actually is.

We're still learning what it really takes for schools to change at scale. How to introduce new ideas without losing trust along the way. How to measure learning that actually matters, not just what's easiest to track. And how to move with some urgency without pushing systems faster than they can realistically move.

That uncertainty isn't something we try to smooth over. It's part of the process, and it shows up in our work every day.

Why The Innovation Hall Exists

The Innovation Hall comes from that same place.

As we've been building TomoClub, it's become pretty clear that we're not the only ones asking these questions. Across schools and communities, educators are quietly figuring things out, testing ideas, and making thoughtful changes without much attention or applause.

The Innovation Hall is simply our way of learning alongside them. It's a space to share real attempts, focus on what actually got implemented, and talk honestly about what worked, what didn't, and why. This first story sets the lens. The next ones will turn it outward, toward others working toward the same goal, one practical step at a time.

Article 2

What It Takes to Prepare Students for Life After Graduation: Martin Madrid

Education is changing daily, but not in predictable ways. It's changing in fragments. In classrooms, in conversations with teachers, and in the growing gap between how students live and how schools still operate.

According to **Martin Madrid**, Superintendent of Santa Rosa Consolidated Schools in New Mexico, we are living through one of those inflection points.

"This is one of the most unique times in education," he says. "It's exciting, but it's also scary."

Martin's perspective comes from experience that is increasingly rare in school leadership. He has spent more than 40 years in the same district - first as a student, then a teacher, principal, and now superintendent. That long arc matters, especially at a time when superintendent turnover is high and trust is often fragile.

Growing Up Inside the System He Now Leads

Martin didn't step into leadership as an outsider. He went to school in the same community he now serves. After college, he returned to teach second grade, later moved into high school classrooms, coached sports, became a principal, and eventually took on the superintendent role.

Seven years into the position, he is now considered a veteran in New Mexico, where the average superintendent tenure is just over two years.

That continuity has shaped how change happens in Santa Rosa. When Martin introduces new ideas, they are grounded in shared history and deep understanding of the community. Innovation doesn't feel imposed. It feels connected to the district's identity.

Why the Current Education Model Feels Out of Sync

Martin doesn't believe students or teachers are failing the system. He believes the system itself has fallen behind.

Students today are growing up immersed in technology. They're using AI, search engines, and digital tools as a natural part of learning and daily life. Schools, however, are still structured around models built for a time when information was scarce and memorization was essential.

Martin sees his role as a bridge - between students who are growing up as digital natives and systems that were built for a very different era. He often finds himself translating between classrooms and policy, between educators who are cautious about change and

students who already live in a technology-driven world. That ability to move between perspectives has shaped how innovation takes root in Santa Rosa.

“We don’t need schools to be places that just deliver information anymore,” Martin explains. “We need them to teach students how to think.”

That mismatch - between how students learn and how schools measure learning - is where many of today’s challenges begin.

How Schools Can Better Prepare Students for the Future

At Santa Rosa Consolidated Schools, future readiness is not framed as a single program or initiative. It is guided by three clear priorities.

1. Using AI as a Learning Tool

AI is often treated with suspicion in schools, largely because of concerns around cheating. Martin takes a different approach.

“Students are going to use AI whether we like it or not,” he says. “The responsibility of schools is to teach them how to use it thoughtfully.”

In Santa Rosa, AI is positioned as a tool that supports critical thinking, exploration, and efficiency. Teachers are encouraged to use it to personalize learning and reduce administrative load, allowing them to focus more on instruction and relationships.

2. Expanding Career and Technical Pathways

For many years, college readiness dominated the definition of success in K–12 education. Martin believes that narrow focus overlooked both student interests and workforce realities.

Santa Rosa has expanded career and technical education (CTE) and work-based learning opportunities so students can explore multiple post-graduation paths. Today, nearly 75% of juniors and seniors participate in internships or hands-on career programs, including welding, construction, culinary arts, healthcare, and other trades.



Beyond technical skills, students develop habits that employers value - communication, reliability, and initiative. In one case, a recent graduate outperformed adult candidates during a professional interview, largely due to her prior internship experience.

3. Strengthening Foundations Through Relevance

Martin is clear that foundational skills like reading, writing, and math remain essential. What needs to change is how students experience them.

When students understand how academic concepts connect to real-world applications, engagement increases. Geometry becomes meaningful in construction. Math matters in culinary budgeting. Literacy supports communication in professional settings.

“When students see the purpose behind what they’re learning,” Martin says, “their motivation changes.”

Why How We Measure Student Learning Needs to Change

Conversations about innovation and future readiness often stall when it comes to measurement. Martin believes this is where many schools feel stuck - caught between how learning is evolving and how success is still defined.

The Disconnect in Today’s Assessment Systems

One of the most significant tensions Martin identifies is in assessment. Schools are encouraged to differentiate instruction and meet students where they are, yet accountability systems still rely heavily on standardized testing. Martin believes this creates a disconnect between how learning happens and how success is measured.

He advocates for a shift toward growth-based assessment models that track individual progress over time, potentially supported by AI-driven data tools.

When Policy Is Far from the Classroom

Martin also points out that many of today's accountability decisions are made far from classrooms. As a former president of New Mexico's Superintendent Association, he has seen how difficult it can be to align policy with the realities of modern learning—especially when those shaping the rules are even further removed from today's technology and classroom environments.

Why Growth Matters More Than Benchmarks

Martin often reflects on how students spend more than a decade inside a highly supported school system, surrounded by teachers, counselors, and resources - and then, almost overnight, that support disappears when they graduate.

Helping students understand growth, self-reflection, and responsibility before that moment, he believes, is just as important as any academic benchmark.

"The real comparison should be a student against their own growth," he explains, "not against a single fixed benchmark."

Innovation in a Small, Rural District

Santa Rosa is a small, rural district with limited resources. That reality has required creative problem-solving.

The district brings in industry professionals as part-time instructors, combines teaching roles with district operational needs, and builds partnerships with the local community. These approaches make it possible to offer robust programs without the scale or funding of larger districts.



According to Martin, once meaningful programs are established, interest follows. Community members want to contribute when they see clear purpose and impact.

Lessons for School Leaders Everywhere

Martin's experience challenges several common assumptions:

- Innovation does not require large budgets
- Rural districts can lead meaningful change
- Academic rigor and relevance are not opposites
- Trust and continuity enable faster progress

Most importantly, his work highlights the need to continuously revisit a fundamental question: what should schools prepare students for today?

Why TomoClub Is Sharing This Story

At TomoClub, we believe the future of education will be shaped by people working inside schools - leaders and educators who are willing to question what no longer works and thoughtfully adapt to what students actually need today.

Tomo Spotlight: Innovations in Education exists to highlight these stories. Not ideal scenarios or polished case studies, but real work happening in real districts, often with limited resources and complex constraints.

Martin Madrid's story reflects the kind of leadership we believe matters most right now - grounded in community, focused on relevance, and willing to rethink long-held assumptions about what school is for.

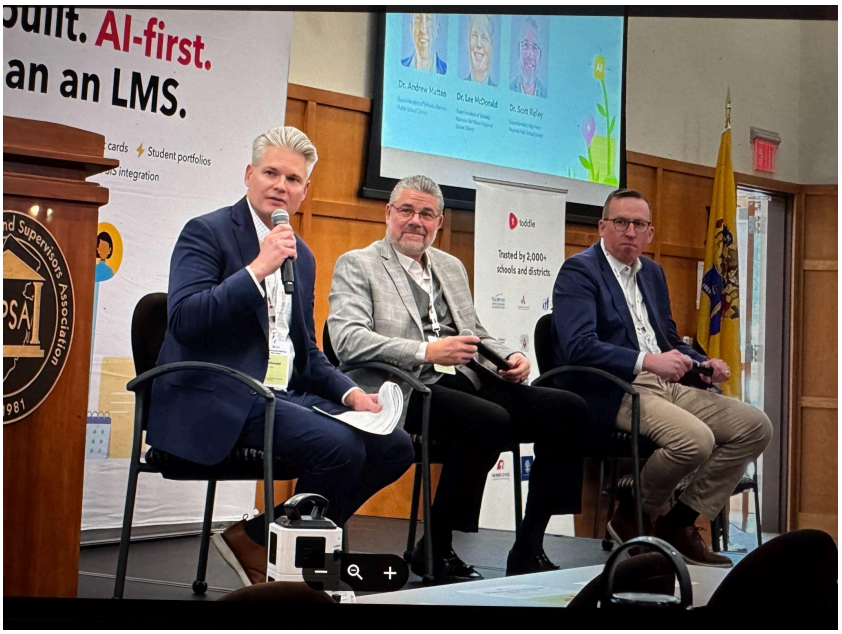
This series is our way of learning from practitioners who quietly shape what comes next for education!

Article 3

How Dr. Scott D. Ripley Expanded Access to AP Courses

“We talk about innovation all the time. But the system itself is built to resist it.”

It’s an honest way to begin a conversation about education, shaped by **Dr. Scott D. Ripley**’s years working closely with schools and educators.



Dr. Ripley presenting at the Toddle AI conference

Scott has spent his career working inside that resistance. A former teacher and coach turned superintendent, he now leads the **High Point Regional High School District** in Sussex County, New Jersey, overseeing a comprehensive public high school serving grades 9–12 and a diverse community of learners.

Along the way, he has seen how deeply schools remain tied to a 19th-century factory model, one that sorts students early, protects adult comfort, and makes meaningful change slow, political, and costly.

For Scott, innovation isn’t about adding new tools or programs. It’s about questioning the structures that quietly decide who gets access to opportunity.

The Experience That Shaped His Belief in Students

Scott’s perspective didn’t come from theory. It came from experience.

As a student, he hated school. He felt invisible. He was told he wasn’t smart, that he had limitations he would need to accept. Learning didn’t feel expansive. It felt like sorting, like being quietly placed into a box and expected to stay there.

Everything changed later, in community college.

A professor didn't look through him or reduce him to past performance. Instead, they believed in him.

"That belief changes everything," Scott told us. For the first time, potential wasn't treated as fixed. It was something that could grow.

What he experienced has a name: **the Pygmalion Effect.** When adults believe in students, students rise to the level of that belief. When they don't, students internalize the ceiling placed above them.

"I believe it wholeheartedly," Scott said. "When people believe in kids, they rise." That belief reshaped how he defines the purpose of education.

"Our job as educators is to inspire kids to love learning and to love themselves." Not as a slogan, but as a responsibility. Because systems either reinforce belief or quietly erode it.

How Schools Quietly Gatekeep Rigor

As Scott stepped into leadership, he began to see a pattern. Education talks often about equity and opportunity. It speaks confidently about rigor and innovation. But when you look closely at how schools actually operate, access is often limited long before students get a real chance to try.

Many systems are still built around adult structures rather than student growth. Tenure rules, grievance processes, political pressures, and long-standing habits shape what happens day to day. Change doesn't just require a good idea. It requires stamina.

And superintendents, without tenure themselves, carry that risk directly. "Change in education requires courage," Scott said. "And very few people are positioned to sustain it."

That reality became clearest in the way schools treated Advanced Placement courses. AP classes were presented as opportunities, but they often operated as filters. Prerequisites, recommendations, and tracking systems quietly decided who was "ready" and who wasn't.

"Readiness became an excuse," Scott said.

Students with IEPs were frequently excluded early. Students without strong advocates were filtered out along the way. Decisions about potential were made years before students had the space to grow into challenges. What was called rigor, Scott realized, was often less about high expectations and more about maintaining comfort within the system.

Who Decides Who Is Ready?

The shift didn't begin with a new program. It began with a decision - one that changed who got to try.

Removing Permission from Rigor

Scott eliminated prerequisites for Advanced Placement courses. No teacher recommendations. No filtering based on past labels. If a student wanted to take an AP class, they could. That included students with IEPs and students who had never been considered “advanced.” Access was no longer something granted. It became something assumed.

Holding the Line Under Pressure

The reaction was immediate. Grievances were filed. Political pressure surfaced. Resistance was steady. “That fight took ten years off my life,” Scott said. But once access became a principle, retreat was not an option. The discomfort was real, but so was the conviction that opportunity should not depend on adult permission.

When Access Expanded, So Did Outcomes

Over time, the impact became measurable. AP offerings grew from 8 to 38 courses. Participation increased from roughly 17% of students to nearly 69%. For Scott, the goal was never exam scores. “It’s not about passing the test,” he said. “It’s about the rigor that prepares students for college.” Research supports that view - students who take AP courses are more likely to persist and graduate, regardless of their exam results.

Changing Adult Mindsets

Structural change required cultural change. “One of the biggest problems,” Scott said, “is thinking kids need to be ready on day one.” They don’t. “Our job is to get them ready by May.” Teachers began to see themselves not as gatekeepers of rigor, but as builders of capacity. That shift made the policy sustainable.

When Everything Becomes About Grades

The work didn’t unfold without tension from families!

Parents today are more involved than ever, but also more anxious and often divided in what they expect from schools. Some want their children protected from pressure and disappointment. Others want them pushed relentlessly toward achievement. In both cases, the conversation often circles back to grades.

“Grades distort learning,” Scott said. In life, failure is how we grow.

But in school, fear of failure can limit risk-taking and stretch. For Scott, leadership meant consistently reframing rigor as growth, not performance - and reminding families that challenge is not punishment. The pressure never fully disappeared. It was absorbed, navigated, and held steady in service of students.

What AI Is Exposing in Schools

AI isn’t simply another innovation to manage. It’s revealing where the system is misaligned with the world students are entering.

The Conversation Can’t Be Rewound

“You can’t put the toothpaste back in the tube,” Scott said. AI isn’t a trend schools can opt out of. It’s already embedded in how students learn and access information.

Resistance Is Understandable - But Limited

Some educators want to remove technology altogether. Others fear it will weaken academic rigor. But eliminating AI doesn’t eliminate the reality students live in outside school.

Personalization Is No Longer Optional

AI makes individualized learning scalable. It challenges rigid, one-size-fits-all models and pushes schools toward student-centered design rather than teacher-centered delivery.

The System Is the Real Constraint

AI doesn’t break schools. It reveals what was already outdated. Structures built for compliance struggle in a world that demands adaptability and critical thinking.

Alignment Becomes the Real Work

For Scott, AI isn’t about novelty. It forces alignment between what schools claim to value - growth, ownership, real-world readiness - and how they actually operate.

What Courage Really Looks Like

Courage in education isn’t abstract. It doesn’t live in speeches or strategy documents. It shows up in conflict. It feels like exhaustion. It carries real professional risk. Superintendents who push too hard often don’t last, not because they lack conviction, but because the system is designed to resist sustained disruption.



Dr. Ripley speaking at a conference

And yet, Scott stayed. “Schools aren’t a social welfare system for adults,” he said. “We’re here for children.” That clarity shaped his decisions when resistance grew loud and pressure intensified. Holding the line wasn’t about winning arguments. It was about staying anchored to purpose.

For Scott, the future of education isn’t mysterious. It is student-centered. It prioritizes access over sorting. It treats belief as foundational, not optional. AI may accelerate change, but it won’t replace the human core of schooling. Relationships, trust, and high expectations remain the real work.

Change is possible. But only if leaders are willing to stay long enough - and steady enough - for it to become part of the culture, not just another initiative.

Why TomoClub Is Sharing This Story

At TomoClub, we believe the future of education is shaped inside schools by leaders who are willing to question what no longer serves students and redesign systems around how learning actually works.

The Education Hall exists to surface these stories - not idealized case studies, but real leadership under real constraints.

Dr. Scott D. Ripley's story reflects the kind of leadership education needs right now. Grounded. Student-centered. And courageous in ways that actually last!

Article 4

How Brenda Ortiz McGrath Is Rewiring Student Support in Education

What if the reason student support “isn’t working” isn’t a lack of care, but a lack of structure?

We have the frameworks, the acronyms, the opening-day presentations. And yet, when attendance dips or behavior spikes, schools often find themselves reacting instead of anticipating. Support becomes something activated during crisis, not embedded into the daily rhythm of a system.

Brenda Ortiz McGrath has built her leadership around changing that equation. For her, student support is not a side initiative. It is infrastructure. It shows up in how teams review data, how classrooms begin their day, how roles are defined, and how families are integrated into planning. It is proactive, structured, and shared.

Because equity, in her view, is not a mission statement. It is a systems decision.

And over the past decade, she has been designing the structures that make that decision real.

About Brenda Ortiz McGrath

Brenda Ortiz McGrath, MSW, is a nationally and internationally recognized educational leader focused on building equitable, prevention-centered systems in public education.

She made history as the first Latina administrator and principal at Waltham High School in its 54-year history. Representation mattered. But for Brenda, breaking a barrier was never the end goal. The deeper work was reshaping how systems function once you are inside them.

She currently serves as a District Administrator overseeing Social Work, Social-Emotional Learning, and Specialized Student Supports, leading aligned frameworks that integrate instruction, wellness, and student support. In addition to district leadership, she also serves as a consultant and national educational leader supporting SEL and MTSS systems alignment across schools and organizations.

She is the Founder of CoreKind360, an emerging initiative designed to integrate instruction, wellness, and family partnership into one coherent system.

Brenda is a doctoral candidate in Educational Leadership, researching the role of social-emotional learning in dropout prevention in urban public schools. She serves as Director-at-Large for the National Organization of Women’s Commissioners, is an elected At-Large member of the Lynn School Committee, and has been named:

- Global Visionary Leader of the Year (2025) by Influencer Magazine (UK)

- Top 50 Educator in the Nation for 2026 by The Educator’s Room



Brenda’s Headshot Image

Awards and titles matter, but the deeper story is about disciplined systems design.

Let’s Stop Waiting for a Crisis

In many schools, support begins after something goes wrong. A student struggles, referral gets submitted then the team responds.

Brenda Ortiz McGrath asks a different question: what if we didn’t wait?

Instead of relying on crisis referrals, she has helped design proactive MTSS systems built around consistent data cycles. Teams review SEL indicators, attendance patterns, behavioral trends, and professional observations together. Not sporadically. Not reactively. Predictably.

The breakthrough is not the data. Most systems already collect it.

The breakthrough is embedding that review process into existing structures so that prevention becomes routine. No extra layer. No parallel initiative. Just clarity of roles, shared protocols, and aligned follow-through.

When support becomes part of how the system operates, sustainability follows.

It Starts in the Classroom

In many schools, social-emotional learning feels separate from instruction. A lesson poster or an advisory block once a week.

Brenda's work reframes that entirely.

If students are dysregulated, disconnected, or unsure if they belong, academic instruction will always face resistance. So rather than treating SEL as an add-on, she supports educators in integrating regulation, belonging, and relationship-building directly into daily classroom practice.



Presenting systems change to education leaders

This includes:

- Predictable routines that increase safety and readiness
- Relationship-building embedded into instruction
- Brief check-ins that surface barriers early
- Viewing behavior as a learning signal, not merely discipline

When classrooms are structured for regulation and connection, engagement rises.

And this connects directly to her doctoral research. Dropout prevention is not a senior-year intervention. It is a systems design choice made much earlier.

Belonging, when embedded into instruction, becomes protective.

Making Family Engagement Part of the System

Family engagement often gets reduced to events.

Brenda's leadership philosophy positions family partnership as infrastructure.

While she does not oversee family liaisons directly, her systems design work embeds family partnership into MTSS and student support frameworks. Communication loops, planning structures, and shared accountability mechanisms are intentionally built so families are integrated into student success planning, not informed after decisions are made.

“Engagement is not an event,” she explains. “It’s infrastructure.”

When families are part of ongoing planning, communication, and shared accountability, student persistence increases. Trust becomes structural rather than situational.

This philosophy continues through CoreKind360, which centers alignment between instruction, wellness, and family partnership as one coordinated system.

Bringing Classroom Insight into Education Policy

Brenda Ortiz McGrath’s leadership does not stop at the school level. It extends into governance, consulting, and national systems alignment work.

As an elected At-Large member of the Lynn School Committee and a Director-at-Large for the National Organization of Women’s Commissioners, she brings practitioner-informed systems thinking into policy spaces. “Policy cannot be disconnected from practice,” she says. “If we design at the top without understanding what happens in classrooms, we create misalignment.”



Brenda connecting with community members locally

Her throughline remains consistent across every role she holds.

“Institutional responsibility matters,” she explains. “When outcomes aren’t where they should be, we have to ask how the system is designed. Blame doesn’t build capacity. Structure does.”

That lens shapes her emphasis on prevention, belonging, and ownership. “If we wait for crisis, we’ve already missed the design opportunity,” she notes. “Belonging and alignment have to be intentional.”

Whether in district leadership, national consulting, or governance, her focus is steady: strengthen the structure so the care already present in schools can actually work.

What Educational Leaders Can Learn

Brenda’s work offers more than a framework. It offers clarity for leaders navigating complexity.

Map the System Before You Fix It

Too often, districts launch new initiatives without diagnosing where breakdowns actually occur.

“You can’t fix what you haven’t mapped,” Brenda explains. “Before adding something new, you have to understand how referral, intervention, follow-up, and communication are currently functioning.”

Improvement begins with visibility. Where does momentum stall? Where does ownership blur? Mapping the system creates the foundation for disciplined change.

Build a Predictable Data Rhythm

Data is only useful if it’s consistent.

“When data review is sporadic, response becomes reactive,” she says. “When it’s built into a rhythm, patterns show up earlier.”

Consistent review cycles reduce crisis. They allow teams to anticipate instead of scramble. Prevention becomes possible because structure is reliable.

Clarify Ownership

Even strong MTSS and SEL frameworks fail when roles are unclear.

“One of the most important questions in any system is: who owns this step?” Brenda notes. “If everyone owns it, no one owns it.”

Clarity does not create rigidity. It creates coordination. When responsibilities are defined, care becomes actionable.

Embed, Don’t Add

Student support cannot sit beside instruction. It must live inside it.

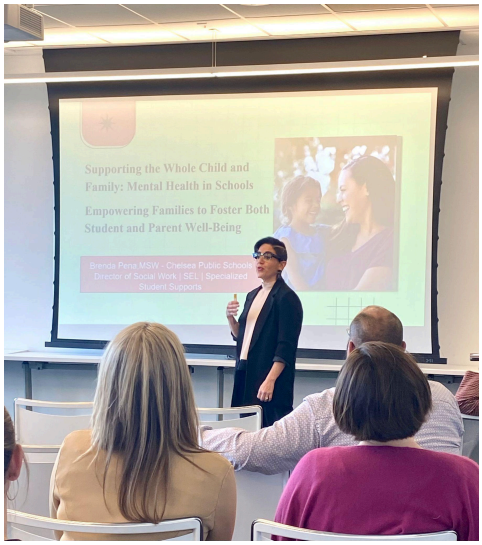
“If it feels like one more thing, it won’t last,” she says plainly.

Integration is the goal. Routines, check-ins, shared language, and regulation practices must be part of daily instruction, not separate initiatives competing for attention.

Start Small. Prove It Works.

Large-scale change does not require a dramatic rollout.

“We led with modeling and data, not mandates,” Brenda explains. “When staff see fewer disruptions and stronger engagement, the buy-in follows.”



Advocating mental health support in schools

Trust grows through evidence. Scale follows proof.

These are not flashy reforms. They are disciplined design decisions. And because they strengthen structure rather than layer programs, they endure.

Why TomoClub Is Sharing This Story

At TomoClub, we believe the future of education is not built through flashy reforms or loud announcements. It is built inside schools by leaders who design systems carefully, earn trust deliberately, and respond to real challenges with intention.

The Education Hall exists to surface these stories. Not polished case studies. Not perfect outcomes. But honest leadership under pressure. Enrollment shifts. Attendance dips. Political scrutiny. Community fear. These are the realities schools navigate every day, and they deserve open conversation, not quiet struggle.

Brenda Ortiz McGrath’s work reflects the kind of leadership that rarely makes headlines but reshapes systems over time. Steady. Structured. Community-centered. The kind that understands a simple truth: before you improve numbers, you build trust. And that kind of leadership is exactly what education needs right now.

Article 5

How Dr. Jill Handley Is Fixing What’s Broken in School Leadership

There's a version of school leadership that looks like dedication but works like dysfunction. The principal who's answering emails at 10 p.m. The district leader who attends every meeting, holds every thread, catches every ball no one else caught. It looks committed from the outside. From the inside, it's a system quietly building toward a breaking point.

Dr. Jill Handley has seen that version. She lived parts of it. And over nearly 30 years in Jefferson County Public Schools - teacher, instructional coach, principal for 16 years, now Assistant Superintendent - she built something different. Not a more disciplined version of the overloaded leader but a different idea of what leadership is supposed to do.

Her conviction is almost aggressively simple: leadership shouldn't require constant sacrifice to be effective. But constructing the systems that make that actually true? That's where most schools stop short.

The part nobody warned her about

Early in her career, Jill Handley wanted her staff to feel supported. And so, like a lot of new leaders, she made decisions with that goal in mind - accommodating individual requests, softening expectations when it kept the peace, prioritizing short-term happiness over long-term alignment.

It took longer than she'd like to admit to see what it was quietly doing to the school.

"I sometimes made decisions that prioritized individual happiness rather than long-term alignment," she says. The result wasn't a happy school. It was a fragmented one. Variance crept up between classrooms. Shared goals blurred. Teachers were doing their own versions of things, and no one had a clear answer to the question: what are we all actually working toward?



Jill with one of the student

The recognition stung. Her instinct to be liked wasn't just a personal quirk, it was limiting what the school could become.

What changed was the architecture underneath everything. She started building an explicit shared vision. Decisions got tied to collective commitments rather than individual preferences. Conversations shifted from *what works for me* to *what best serves what we're building together*.

The trust that followed didn't come from being harder. It came from being clearer. And clarity, it turns out, is one of the most underrated things a leader can give people.

What she fixed before anything else

By the time she was leading Kenwood Elementary, she had a fully developed theory about sustained growth. The theory: structure is the prerequisite for everything else. Here’s what she did:

The master schedule was the first move

Before any new curriculum, before any new initiative, Handley redesigned the master schedule. Common planning time built in for grade-level teams. Protected Tier 1 instructional blocks. Intervention woven into the day rather than piled on after it.

"Without a schedule that protects collaboration, intervention time, and coaching cycles, none of the other work is sustainable," she says.

Data became a team sport

MAP data stopped living only with the principal. PLCs became real working sessions - disciplined, focused on specific questions: what are students mastering, what aren't they, and what's the team doing about it before next week?

Students tracked their own growth targets. Teachers aligned instructional strategies to those targets and got regular, actionable feedback on whether their choices were actually working.

Growth was built into the daily rhythm of the school.

Coaching replaced compliance

Handley developed what she called **Individualized Professional Development** - a coaching cycle built around observation, feedback, collaborative planning, and follow-up. High expectations for instruction were paired with high support for getting there.



Jill speaking for the community

Teachers knew what strong instruction looked like. They also knew they'd receive real coaching to reach it, not just the expectation hanging over them. Over time, that built collective efficacy. Staff could see the direct connection between their instructional decisions and student growth.

Celebration was strategic

Recognition wasn't just feel-good. Handley made it intentional - publicly recognizing student growth, grade-level gains, staff achievements. Celebrating progress reinforced belief. And belief, she found, is what sustains momentum when the work gets hard.

Why leading a district is a different job

Moving from principal to Assistant Superintendent is where a lot of strong building leaders quietly lose their footing. The feedback loops that made them effective, seeing impact quickly, staying close to instruction, knowing every teacher by name, those compress or disappear entirely at the district level.

Handley is candid about the adjustment. At the building level, you implement. At the district level, you create coherence. And the instinct to do the first one when you've been hired for the second is a real trap.

The mindset shift she describes is worth sitting with: leaders, like teachers, are at varying stages of development. Good district leadership has to differentiate for building leaders the same way good instruction differentiates for students. That meant listening first. Observing. Understanding what was already in place before pushing on anything.



Jill as a keynote speaker

"I spent significant time learning the landscape," she says, "identifying both short-term levers that could produce immediate impact and longer-term structural shifts that would strengthen outcomes over time."

She brought the habit of scanning across multiple schools and asking where alignment was quietly breaking down, where gaps in student experience were being created by silos that

didn't need to exist, where clarity was missing in ways that made everyone's job harder than it needed to be.

Her goal was never to replace what was working. It was to find where the connective tissue between things was weak - and reinforce it.

Building for the students who get left out

In her current role leading the Office of Multilingual Learners, Handley is running the same structural playbook - this time on behalf of a student that too many school systems still treat as peripheral.

Her framework runs on three pillars. Each one has to be in place. None of them works without the others.

- **Vision:** "If leaders see students only through a deficit lens, systems will reflect that." When multilingualism gets framed as an asset instead of a deficiency - when cultural diversity is treated as strength - it changes what gets scheduled, how instruction gets designed, what professional development gets funded, who gets access to advanced coursework. Belief isn't soft. It's structural. It determines what gets built.

- **Systems:** Strong Tier 1 instruction with language supports embedded. Real collaboration structures between general education and ML staff. Accountability measures that track access and outcomes - not just test scores at year's end, but whether students have a genuine pathway through the full academic program of the school. "It's not enough to say we value multilingual learners; we must build structures that demonstrate that commitment."

- **Leadership capacit:** Helping building leaders examine their data through an equity lens, notice patterns in discipline and access to advanced coursework, and lead inclusive schools with both skill and intention. "Supporting leaders in this work requires both clarity and courage." Clarity because the work has to be specific and concrete. Courage because it means naming patterns that are uncomfortable to name.

What schools are getting wrong about AI

"School and district leaders should be thinking less about the tool itself and more about the conditions surrounding its use."

AI can do real things. It can support differentiated instruction in ways that used to be logistically impossible. It can handle administrative load, give faster feedback, expand access to information. Used with intention, it genuinely helps. But it can't build trust. It can't create belonging. It can't do the relationship work that determines whether any of the rest of it actually sticks.

Her concern is equity, specifically, what happens when AI gets rolled out without asking who it serves and who it leaves behind. The students and schools that already have less will fall further behind if implementation happens without intentional design. District leaders need to provide professional learning, ethical frameworks, and guardrails before rolling anything out, not after.

The integration question she's asking isn't *which tool?* Does *this serve the learning goals we already have, or does it become another initiative layered on top of everything we haven't finished yet?*

AI should serve learning. Not drive it.

Same logic she's applied to everything else across 30 years. The tool isn't the strategy. The system is.

What she's actually trying to leave behind

There's a sentence Dr. Handley returns to again and again: *leadership should not require constant sacrifice to be effective.*

It sounds like a wellness slogan until you understand what it's really arguing. When leadership concentrates on one person, when the principal is the answer to every question, the backstop for every breakdown, the keeper of every thread, the system is fragile. Not because that person isn't exceptional. Because no one can sustain that indefinitely. And because that model doesn't build anything that outlasts them.

What she's built, across every role in 30 years, is something different: shared ownership. Systems clear enough that people understand their responsibilities. Coaching is real enough that high expectations are actually achievable. Recognition consistent enough that people feel seen rather than managed.

She also hosts *Be The Leader You Deserve* and co-authored *What Can I Take Off Your Plate*, both rooted in the same conviction her school leadership was. Growing other leaders isn't extra credit. It's the main job. The leaders you develop are the system's ability to sustain itself after you've moved on.



Jill at her book signing event

"Sustainable leadership," she says, "is not measured by how much you carry, but by how many others you empower to lead alongside you."

When people look back on her work years from now, she hopes they say she led with integrity, that her words and her actions matched. That she held high expectations out of genuine belief in people, not out of pressure. That she left every space stronger, more aligned, more hopeful than she found it.

Not because she was still there holding it together. Because the people inside it felt equipped to carry it forward themselves.

Why TomoClub Is Sharing This Story

At TomoClub, we believe the future of education isn't shaped by flashy reforms. It's shaped inside schools by leaders who quietly build systems, strengthen trust, and respond to real challenges with intention.

The Education Hall exists to surface these stories. Dr. Handley's career spans three decades of exactly that: leading Title I schools with limited resources, navigating the often-disorienting shift from building to district leadership, and advocating for multilingual learners inside systems that weren't originally built with them in mind. These are the realities most schools live with every day, and they deserve to be talked about honestly.

Dr. Jill Handley's work at Jefferson County Public Schools reflects a kind of leadership that rarely makes headlines. Steady. Systems-driven. Relentlessly people-first. The kind that

understands that before you can improve outcomes, you have to build the structures that make improvement possible - and that those structures only hold when the people inside them feel valued, coached, and trusted to carry the work forward. That kind of leadership is exactly what education needs right now.

Article 6

How Michael Mai held great meadows together when the money ran out



There's a moment Michael Mai keeps coming back to.

He'd just started as principal of Great Meadows Regional School District. New building, new community, no established reputation. A parent approached him at a school event. She wasn't complaining. She wasn't requesting anything. She was just... surprised.

She was impressed that he knew all the students' names.

"What seemed to me as just a part of my job carried a whole other level of meaning for the students and their families," he says.

That moment didn't just stick with him. It became the lens through which he'd eventually see everything: fiscal crises, COVID shutdowns, contract fights, AI rollouts. The idea that knowing people, actually knowing them, isn't some soft leadership bonus. It's the job. And if you let go of it when things get hard, you've already lost.

In 2020, Mai stepped into the superintendent role at the worst possible moment. COVID protocols, teacher contract negotiations, state monitoring, and $3.8 million in cumulative state aid losses, all at once, in year one. Most leaders would've gone into pure survival mode. What Mai did instead was communicate. Relentlessly, transparently, sometimes uncomfortably.

What followed was more than a decade of leadership that tells you something real about what it takes to keep a small school district intact when the ground keeps shifting.

The road in (And what it actually taught him)

Mai didn't take a straight line to the superintendent's office. He started in Jersey City at a school with tremendous potential stuck under leadership that couldn't get out of its own way. It frustrated him enough to go back to school. In 2006, he enrolled in educational leadership courses at the University of Scranton. Not because he had a mapped-out plan, but because he kept thinking about what different leadership would actually look like.

He moved to Hackettstown, NJ, fell for the community, and taught 4th grade for five years. Then came the assistant principal role at Hackettstown Middle School, where he was working with many of the same kids he'd once taught. The relationship part of the job didn't disappear when he stopped being a classroom teacher. It just changed shape.

When the principal position opened in Great Meadows, a district that feeds directly into Hackettstown High School, it felt like a natural move. He learned the inner workings of the district under Superintendent David Mango, who became both his boss and his mentor. When Mango eventually moved on, Mai applied for the role.

He got it.

In August 2020.

"I have often said that if I could survive that, I can handle anything," he says. Looking at what hit him in year one, a global pandemic, a multi-year funding crisis, contract negotiations, and state accountability monitoring, you believe him.

Here's where the money got really ugly

Between 2017 and 2024, Great Meadows Regional lost approximately $3.8 million in state aid funding. New Jersey's S2 law was designed to move money away from overfunded districts toward those that had historically been underfunded. The intent wasn't wrong. The impact on Great Meadows was brutal.

The district landed in the top 10 in New Jersey for the most money lost under S2. For a small suburban-rural district, that's not a budget line problem. That's an existential one.

Cutting without gutting the core

Mai's approach wasn't to quietly absorb the losses and hope nobody noticed. He made two things non-negotiable from the start: keep as many jobs as possible, and keep programs running. Everything else was on the table.

He shopped for health benefits annually, finding the best deals rather than defaulting to automatic renewals. He issued RFPs for transportation, legal services, and architectural work to find cost-effective providers. Small moves, each of them. But in a district operating on thin margins, small moves are exactly how you survive.

Then COVID hit. And the federal relief funds that followed created an opening nobody had expected.

"By utilizing federal funds made available as a result of Covid-19, Great Meadows Regional was able to renew curricular programs and provide programs beyond the school day," Mai explains.

The district used those funds to restore what seven years of S2 cuts had hollowed out: curriculum, extended learning, summer programs for the students hit hardest by the shutdown. They also used the money to save jobs that would otherwise have been eliminated.

It's an irony Mai acknowledges without embarrassment. The worst educational disruption in a generation ended up providing the financial runway to preserve the district's core. Sometimes the crisis carries the solution inside it. You just have to stay calm enough to see it.

What "People-First" looks like when you're actually under pressure

Ask Mai about his leadership philosophy and he reaches for a sports analogy almost immediately. He sees himself as the Team President, not the one calling plays on the field, but the one making sure the General Managers (his principals) have what they need to support the Coaches (teachers) and the Players (students).

It's a useful frame. But what makes it real is how he talks about the less glamorous parts of the work.

He holds three Virtual Town Halls per year. He recently started doing live "Ask Me Anything" segments on the district's YouTube channel. This year, Great Meadows was featured in BusinessView Magazine. A monthly district newsletter launched. He doesn't describe any of this as marketing or outreach. He talks about it as obligation.

"Without trust and communication, a district cannot successfully move forward," he says. "By maintaining transparent communication with all members of our school community, everyone knows where they stand."

That includes the hard stuff. Fiscal realities. Program constraints. Difficult decisions with no clean answers. The instinct for many leaders is to manage the message, soften the edges, bury the bad news in careful language. Mai's instinct is to just say the thing, explain the reasoning, and let people respond.

What He Actually Expects from His Teachers

His evaluation feedback to teachers consistently comes back to two things: student engagement and differentiation. When a teacher struggles in those areas, his first response is professional development, not punishment.

Both schools in Great Meadows operate on the Professional Learning Community model, which builds daily and weekly time for teacher collaboration directly into the schedule. Monthly articulation time lets subject and grade-level teams align curriculum, assessment, and instructional practice. None of that is unusual on paper. What's unusual is that Mai treats it as foundational, not a nice-to-have that gets quietly cut when schedules get tight.

"Education is a people business," he says. "You can have all the shiny bells and whistles in the world, but you will not motivate a child to learn if you do not connect with them on a human level."

Learn their names. Learn their favorite shows, their TikTok trends, their musical tastes. Care about your staff as people, not just employees. Understand that family comes first. These aren't warm platitudes the way he says them. They're operational.

Now the next chapter: AI

Great Meadows is growing again. Enrollment is up. Preschool is expanding. The district that spent seven years in financial triage is starting to rebuild what was lost, and into that rebuilding moment comes artificial intelligence.

Mai isn't a skeptic about AI, but he's not a convert either. He's something rarer and more useful: someone asking the right questions. His district recently partnered with EduTech, their IT provider, to develop a formal AI Plan with age- and grade-level guidelines, guardrails against misuse, and realistic frameworks for actual classroom use.

His position is unambiguous: teachers need to understand AI before students touch it. Students need real training on safe, effective use before they're permitted to apply it to assignments. The goal isn't efficiency for its own sake.

"AI allows them to dive deeper into topics," he says. "So expectations may need to be raised for what can be accomplished with these tools."

That last sentence is easy to scroll past. Most of the conversation around AI in education circles revolves around risk management, cheating, misinformation, over-reliance, the slow erosion of fundamental skills. Mai is asking a different question. If students now have access to tools that can accelerate and expand their thinking, shouldn't we expect *more* from them?

It's the same instinct that shaped his whole career. Don't manage down to the constraint. Figure out what's actually possible and push there.

The future he describes for Great Meadows is more inclusive classrooms, smarter AI integration, a growing preschool that gives the youngest learners an earlier foundation, and partnerships with neighboring districts to optimize programs without blowing the budget. And underneath all of it, the same thing that made that parent stop him in the hallway all those years ago.

"We want to help create good people who love to learn," he says.

That's the goal. The funding fights, the COVID pivots, the RFPs, the AI plans, the town halls - that's all just what it takes to get there.

The Part Nobody Warns You About

Mai's advice to emerging leaders isn't complicated, but it is honest in a way that a lot of leadership advice isn't.

The first thing he'll tell you: you won't please everyone. Trying to will paralyze you. Make the best decision you can for the people in your charge, explain your reasoning clearly, and accept that respect and agreement aren't the same thing. People can disagree with a decision and still trust the person who made it. That's actually the goal.

The second thing is harder. Know when to push and when to back off. He invokes the old question, *is this a hill worth dying on?*, not as a cliché but as a real daily check. You can be completely right about a needed change and still read the timing completely wrong. If the staff, the community, and the board aren't ready, pushing anyway doesn't make you brave. It just makes the change harder when you eventually get it through.

"Be willing to regroup and move in a different direction," he says. And coming from someone who navigated $3.8 million in losses without losing his footing, that reads less like a management tip and more like hard-won wisdom.

The Name Thing Was Never Small

Michael Mai took over a district in crisis and spent years doing unglamorous work: keeping jobs intact, renegotiating contracts, hunting for cheaper health benefits, writing honest budget letters to a community that deserved honesty. No dramatic turnaround arc. No silver bullet. Just clear communication, creative problem-solving, and the stubborn insistence on knowing every kid's name.

That parent who stopped him in the hallway probably didn't know what the moment meant to him. It confirmed that the relational work he'd built his whole identity around as a teacher didn't disappear when he moved up. It just reached further.

Great Meadows is rebuilding now. The enrollment is climbing. The preschool is growing. The AI plan is in motion. And at the center of it is a superintendent who still believes the most important thing he can do is make sure every student in his district knows they've been seen.

That might sound small, but it isn't.

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At TomoClub, we believe the future of education isn't shaped by flashy reforms. It's shaped inside schools by leaders who quietly build systems, strengthen trust, and respond to real challenges with intention.

The Education Hall exists to surface these stories - not polished case studies, but honest leadership under real pressure. Michael Mai faced the kind of year-one gauntlet that would've broken a lot of people: a global pandemic, a seven-year funding crater worth $3.8 million, contract negotiations, and state accountability monitoring, all landing at once. These aren't hypothetical pressures. They're the ones small districts across the country are living with right now - just rarely all at the same time.

Michael Mai's work at Great Meadows Regional reflects a kind of leadership that often goes unnoticed. Steady. Relational. Fiscally creative. The kind that understands that before you can improve outcomes, you have to earn trust - from your board, your staff, your community, and yes, the kid in the hallway whose name you actually know. That kind of leadership is exactly what education needs right now.